

The House on Elm Street

She had always known her father was complicated.
She had not known how much she did not know.

CEFR Level A2

Book 9 of 9

Adult Graded Reader

Setting: A house in a small English town. Present day, with elements of the past.

Genre: Family Drama / Mystery

Characters

- Clare — 43. Financial analyst. Precise, organised. Not especially close to her father.
- Robert — Clare's father. Died six weeks ago. Age 79.
- Nora — 71. A woman Clare finds a reference to in her father's study.
- Marcus — 47. Clare's brother. Lives abroad. Mostly unhelpful.

Clare arrived at the house on a Saturday morning in October.

She had a key but stood at the door for a full minute before using it.

The house smelled of her father: old books, pipe tobacco though he had not smoked for fifteen years, and something floral she could never identify.

He had died six weeks ago. Heart failure. He had been alone.

The solicitor had told her: nothing unusual in the will. The house to Clare and Marcus, equally.

She had come to begin clearing it.

Clare started in the study. Her father had been a meticulous man.

Files for each year going back to 1965. Folders for bills, correspondence, investments, property.

Clare worked through them systematically.

At the back of the bottom drawer, behind a folder labelled 1971 — Miscellaneous, she found a small photograph.

It showed her father — young, maybe thirty — with a woman Clare did not recognise.

They were standing on a beach, laughing.

Clare did not know her father had ever laughed like that.

Clare put the photograph on the desk and looked at it while she worked.

The woman was perhaps twenty-five. Dark hair, cut short. She had a hand on Robert's arm.

On the back, in her father's handwriting: N. and me. Falmouth, 1972.

N. Clare tried to think of women in her father's life with that initial.

Her mother's name had been Patricia. She had died when Clare was eleven.

'N.,' Clare said to the room.

Clare called her brother that evening. Marcus was in Singapore.

'I found a photograph. Of Dad. With a woman. N. and me — Falmouth, 1972.'

Marcus was quiet for a moment. 'Before Mum?' 'Yes. He would have been thirty. Mum and Dad married in 1975.'

'It's probably nothing,' Marcus said.

Clare looked at the photograph. Her father was laughing. She had never seen him laugh like that.

The next morning, Clare found the letters.

They were in a locked tin box in the wardrobe, behind winter coats.

The key was on her father's key ring — smaller than the others, purpose unknown until now.

Inside the tin: fourteen letters addressed to Robert.

They were signed: Nora.

The first was dated May 1970. The last was dated November 1974.

Clare sat on the floor of the bedroom and began to read.

The letters were careful, intelligent, affectionate.

Nora wrote about her work as a nurse, about books, about places she had visited.

She wrote about Robert with a warmth Clare had never associated with her father.

He was, in Nora's letters, funny. Perceptive. Kind.

'You always see things that other people miss,' Nora wrote in 1972. 'That's one of my favourite things about you.'

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Clare returns to her father's house to clear it after his death.

Clare read all fourteen letters in two hours. When she finished, she sat for a long time.

The last letter was dated November 1974. It was shorter than the others.

Nora wrote:

Robert, I understand. I do. But I want you to know that I will think about this differently than you do. You have made a practical decision. I have lost something I cannot replace.

I hope she makes you happy. I genuinely hope that. Please don't write back. I think that would make it harder.

Nora.

Clare read it three times. Then she put it carefully back with the others.

Clare spent the afternoon going through her mother's things.

Patricia had died at forty-three. Clare had been eleven. She had very few memories of her mother being happy. Her parents' marriage had been not unhappy, exactly, but careful. Formal. Two people who had chosen each other for reasons Clare had always found hard to understand.

She thought about Nora's letter. You have made a practical decision.

She wondered: had her mother known? Had anyone known?

She called Marcus again.

'Did you know about Nora?' Clare asked.

'Who is Nora?' 'Dad's — someone he was with before Mum. Someone he chose not to be with.'

Marcus was quiet. 'No. I didn't know about a Nora.'

'He had fourteen letters from her. He kept them in a locked tin box for fifty years.'

There was a long pause.

'That's not Dad,' Marcus said. 'Dad didn't do things like that.'

'I'm holding the tin box,' Clare said. 'He did.'

Clare spent two days searching for Nora.

She knew: a nurse, in the early 1970s, possibly from the south-west given the Falmouth photograph.

On the second day, she found a Nora Helen Marsh in a nursing alumni association newsletter from 2019.

It mentioned her retirement from the NHS after forty years.

It gave her general location: the south-west.

It mentioned that she was a keen amateur botanist.

Clare stared at the screen. Her father had kept a garden for thirty years.

Clare wrote Nora a letter. She spent most of an evening on it.

She explained who she was — Robert's daughter. She said she had found letters in her father's things after his death.

She said: I am not trying to disturb you or raise old difficulties. I just wanted to let you know that he had kept your letters. He kept them for fifty years.

She did not ask any questions. She said: you do not need to reply.

She posted it via the alumni association. Then she went back to clearing the house.

While she waited, Clare spent time in the garden.

Her father had maintained it carefully for thirty years: roses, sweet peas, and a large variety of herbs.

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A photograph and fourteen letters reveal a past she never knew.

She found his gardening notebook on the potting shed shelf.

It was full of notes in his small, precise handwriting: planting dates, soil conditions, what had worked and what hadn't.

'You always see things that other people miss,' she remembered Nora writing.

She looked at the notebook. He had seen things.

The reply came three weeks later on cream paper.

Dear Clare, Thank you for writing. I was very sorry to hear about Robert.

I am glad you told me about the letters. I had wondered sometimes whether he had kept them.

He was a good man. He made a choice that hurt me at the time. But I have had a full life, and I believe he did too.

If you would like to speak, I am willing. But please do not feel any obligation.

Nora.

Clare called Nora on a Sunday afternoon. Nora's voice was steady and warm.

They talked for an hour. Nora told her about the Robert she had known in the early 1970s.

He had been working at a hospital in Bristol. She had been a nurse on his ward.

'He was not like the other doctors,' Nora said. 'He actually listened to patients.'

Clare was taking notes, which she knew was strange.

'Why did he end it?' Clare asked, eventually.

'His family,' Nora said simply. 'His father. It was a different time.'

'Did you ever see him again?' Clare asked.

'Once. In 1982. A conference in London. We had coffee.'

'How was it?' 'Strange. Polite. He showed me photographs of his children.'

Clare realised she had been one of those photographs.

'He looked well,' Nora said. 'Settled. I think he was happy enough.' She paused.

'I chose not to find that painful.'

Clare thought about that sentence for a long time after the call.

Marcus flew in for a weekend in November. Clare showed him the photograph and the letters.

He read two of the letters. Then he put them down.

'He never talked about any of this,' Marcus said. 'No,' Clare agreed.

'Did it change how you think about him?'

Clare had been asking herself this for three weeks.

'Yes. But not in the way I expected. I knew less of him than I thought. And knowing more makes me feel — not worse about him. Closer to him, maybe.'

Marcus looked at the photograph. Their father, laughing.

Before Marcus left, they went into the garden together.

Clare showed him the gardening notebook. 'He tracked everything. Every year. Notes from 1988.'

'He was precise about things he cared about,' Clare said.

Marcus looked at the rose Clare had tied back. He looked at the herbs.

'Are you going to sell the house?' 'Eventually. But not yet.' Clare looked at the garden.

'I want to plant the sweet peas in the spring. He always planted them in March.'

Marcus looked at her. 'You're turning into him,' he said. Clare said: 'I know.'

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The mystery leads Clare toward a fuller truth about her father.

In their second phone call, Clare mentioned the garden. Nora asked what was in it.

Clare described it. 'Sweet peas,' Nora said. 'He always loved sweet peas. Even in Bristol — he had a window box.'

Clare was quiet. She had not known this.

'He kept the same things,' she said.

'Some things you don't let go of,' Nora said. 'Even when you let go of other things.'

Clare thought about the tin box in the wardrobe. The key on his key ring she had never known the use of.

He had kept the letters. He had kept the window box. He had kept both.

By December, the house was mostly cleared.

Clare had kept a few things: the gardening notebook, the photograph, the letters.

She had given Marcus the dining table and the books. She had donated the rest.

She stood in the empty front room on the last day.

The floral smell was still there — she had never identified it.

She asked Nora about it in their third call.

'That's sweet pea,' Nora said immediately. 'He wore it as a fragrance. Even in the seventies.'

Clare stood in the empty room. She breathed it in.

In March, Clare planted the sweet peas.

She had sold the house, but the new owners had said she could use the garden until they moved in.

She knelt in the soil with her father's notebook open beside her.

She followed his notes exactly — the depth, the spacing, the date.

She thought about the man laughing on a beach in 1972.

She thought about the man tracking his roses year by year.

She thought about a tin box with a small key.

She patted the soil down. 'There,' she said to no one.

She went home. She called Nora.

Story Vocabulary

The words below are collected from the story. They are given together so the reading pages stay like a real story book.

1. pipe tobacco	pipo tütünü
2. solicitor	avukat
3. will	vasiyetname
4. heart failure	kalp yetmezliği
5. clearing	boşaltmak
6. identify	tanımlamak
7. meticulous	titiz, düzenli
8. systematically	sistematik olarak
9. correspondence	yazışma
10. bottom drawer	alt çekmece
11. labelled	etiketlenmiş
12. miscellaneous	çeşitli
13. initial	baş harf
14. handwriting	el yazısı
15. cut short	kısa kesilmiş
16. before Mum	anneden önce
17. married in 1975	1975'te evlendiler
18. probably nothing	muhtemelen hiçbir şey
19. quiet for a moment	bir an sessiz
20. tin box	teneke kutu
21. wardrobe	dolap
22. key ring	anahtarlık
23. addressed to	... adresine
24. dated	tarihli
25. locked	kilitli
26. affectionate	sevgi dolu
27. associated with	... ile ilişkilendirmek
28. perceptive	anlayışlı, keskin
29. warmth	sıcaklık
30. intelligent	zekice
31. practical decision	pratik karar
32. replace	yerini doldurmak
33. genuinely	içtenlikle
34. harder	daha zor
35. lost something	bir şey kaybetti
36. formal	resmi, mesafeli
37. chosen each other	birbirini seçmiş
38. hard to understand	anlamak zor

39. wondered	merak etti
40. chose not to be with	... ile olmamayı seçti
41. didn't do things like that	böyle şeyler yapmazdı
42. holding	tutuyor
43. alumni association	mezunlar derneği
44. keen	hevesli
45. amateur botanist	amatör botanikçi
46. south-west	güneybatı
47. newsletter	bülten
48. disturb	rahatsız etmek
49. raise old difficulties	eski güçlükleri gündeme getirmek
50. via	aracılığıyla
51. posted it	gönderdi
52. kept them	sakladı
53. maintained	bakımını yaptı
54. sweet peas	bezelye çiçekleri
55. potting shed	bahçe kulübesi
56. soil conditions	toprak koşulları
57. precise handwriting	düzgün el yazısı
58. obligation	yükümlülük
59. full life	dolu bir hayat
60. hurt me at the time	o zamanlar beni incitti
61. willing	istekli
62. cream paper	krem rengi kağıt
63. steady	sakin, istikrarlı
64. ward	koğuş, servis
65. took notes	not aldı
66. eventually	sonunda
67. different time	farklı bir dönem
68. conference	konferans
69. settled	yerleşmiş, sakin
70. polite	kibarca
71. painful	acı verici
72. chose not to find it	bunu acı bulmamayı seçti
73. happy enough	yeterince mutlu
74. flew in	uçakla geldi
75. agreed	katıldı
76. expected	bekledi

77. closer to	... e daha yakın
78. knew less of him	onu daha az tanıyordum
79. tracked	takip etti
80. precise	titiz, hassas
81. plant the sweet peas	bezelye çiçeklerini dikmek
82. turning into	dönüşüyor
83. eventually	eninde sonunda
84. window box	pencere önü çiçekliği
85. let go of	bırakmak
86. kept the same things	aynı şeyleri korudu
87. described it	anlattı
88. donated	bağışladı
89. empty front room	boş oturma odası
90. fragrance	parfüm, koku
91. breathed it in	içini çekti
92. mostly cleared	büyük ölçüde boşaltılmış
93. knelt in the soil	toprağa çömeldi
94. depth	derinlik
95. spacing	aralık
96. tracking his roses	güllerin kaydını tutmak
97. patted the soil down	toprağı bastırdı

After-Reading Activities

1. Vocabulary Practice — Match the Words

Match each word with the correct meaning.

Word

Meaning

1. solicitor

A. vasiyetname

2. will

B. avukat

3. meticulous

C. titiz

4. affectionate

D. sevgi dolu

5. obligation

E. yükümlülük

6. fragrance

F. parfüm

7. mutual friends

G. ortak arkadaşlar

8. botanist

H. botanikçi

2. Fill in the Blanks

Choose the correct word from the box and write it in the blank.

practical — kept — closer — letters — garden — chose

1. Nora's last letter said: you have made a _____ decision.

2. Clare's father _____ Nora's letters for fifty years in a locked tin box.

3. Nora said: I _____ not to find it painful.

4. Clare found fourteen _____ from Nora in a locked box in the wardrobe.

5. Her father kept a _____ for thirty years — sweet peas, roses, herbs.

6. Knowing more about her father made Clare feel _____ to him.

3. Comprehension Questions

True or False? Write T or F.

1. Clare's father was a very open, communicative man. ____
2. Clare finds the photograph in the wardrobe. ____
3. Marcus immediately knows who Nora is. ____
4. Nora is still alive at the time of the story. ____
5. Robert and Nora met once more after their relationship ended. ____
6. Clare keeps the house at the end. ____

Short Answer Questions

7. What does Clare find in the study, and what surprises her about it?
8. Who was Nora, and what happened to their relationship?
9. What does the last letter from Nora say?
10. What does Clare learn about her father from the phone call with Nora?
11. How does Clare feel about knowing more about her father?
12. What does Nora tell Clare about the sweet pea fragrance?
13. What does Marcus notice about Clare by the end?
14. What does Clare keep from the house, and why?
15. What does the final scene of the story show?

Answer Key

(Alıştırmaları yaptıktan sonra bakınız.)

Match: 1-B 2-A 3-C 4-D 5-E 6-F 7-G 8-H

Fill in the Blanks: 1. practical 2. kept 3. chose 4. letters 5. garden
6. closer

True / False: 1. F 2. F 3. F 4. T 5. T 6. F

7. A photograph of her father laughing with a woman on a beach.
She had never seen
him laugh like that.

8. Nora was a nurse Robert knew in the early 1970s. He ended the
relationship due to
family pressure — his father. He then married Clare's mother.

9. That she understands, but sees it differently — he made a
practical decision, she lost
something irreplaceable. She hopes Clare's mother makes him
happy and asks him not
to write back.

10. That he was funny, perceptive, kind, and actually listened to
patients — different
from the father Clare knew.

11. Not worse about him — closer to him. Knowing more helped
her understand who he
really was.

12. That he had worn sweet pea fragrance since the 1970s — she
recognised it
immediately.

13. He says she is turning into their father. She agrees.

14. The gardening notebook, the photograph, and the letters —
things that show who
he really was.

15. Clare plants sweet peas following her father's notes exactly,
then calls Nora —
continuing the connection.